

MYTH 2: WEALTHY PEOPLE ARE JUST LUCKY

TRUTH: 76% of millionaires say that anyone in America can become a millionaire with discipline and hard work.

Michael Phelps is unquestionably the most successful Olympian in history. Now retired, he brought home more Olympic medals than any other athlete in any sport. He started his Olympic career at age fifteen in 2000, when he became one of the youngest males to ever make the Olympic team. He didn't medal that year, but he made a big splash, so to speak, on the international swimming scene. In the 2004, 2008, 2012, and 2016 Summer Games, with a little more experience under his belt, Phelps was unstoppable. He racked up medal after medal in several different swimming events. In all, Phelps brought home twenty-eight medals—twenty-three of which are gold—before retiring from Olympic competition. Most swimmers competing against him over the past fifteen years probably hit the pool just hoping to come in second.

The thing that's really interesting about Michael Phelps isn't just his success; it's the fact that he was *made* to swim. I don't mean that metaphorically; I mean his body is custom-engineered for swimming. I've seen research breaking down his physical advantages, and it's crazy. His arms are longer and his hands are larger than average, enabling him to move more water with each stroke. His feet are bigger than average for his height, giving him a 10% advantage with each kick. He has a disproportionately long torso compared to his legs. His chest is double-jointed. His lung capacity is off the charts.⁷ Like fellow gold-medal swimmer Rowdy Gaines said, "If you're putting together a human being from science, this is what you want."

It would be easy to write Phelps off as *lucky*, attributing all his success to genetic factors that he was born with. And, while all those genetic advantages make him a powerful force in the water, they wouldn't mean a